

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a parenting column of a newspaper in Hong Kong:

Why spoilt kids need a stay in boot camp to toughen up

Here's my prediction for the next growth industry: boot camps for children.

They are very popular with Korean parents, who send their kids off to these army-style boot camps where youngsters are shouted at, made to do difficult exercise, clean toilets, and sleep in basic conditions that shock many of the kids sent there. Parents send them because they are worried that the modern generation is too soft and spoiled.

Research has found that over-protective parenting occurs more frequently in educated and professional households, and that richer children complain more and are less self-sufficient. The recent story of maids going to university halls to clean rooms for Hong Kong students speaks for itself and would seem to corroborate the claim that many Hong Kong students are overprotected and lack independence.

Boot camp forces children to face a difficult and challenging environment on their own in the hope that it will build those skills that the modern generation are often lacking. After two weeks cleaning toilets, eating basic food and running up mountains, parents hope their kids will better deal with managing disappointment.

I've been threatening my daughter with a Korean style boot camp for years, ever since the time we stayed in the Peninsula Hotel, and she argued that the Venetian Macau was preferable. She knows this threat is empty, but honestly, if there were boot camps in Hong Kong, I'd be the first customer.

Your Liberal Studies class is doing a project on the problems faced by children who are spoilt and over-protected by their parents. You have been asked to discuss whether boot camps would be suitable for Hong Kong. You may want to talk about:

- what children might learn in a boot camp
- whether boot camp would be popular with Hong Kong parents
- other methods to encourage students to be more independent
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Would you like to go to a boot camp?
2. How would you feel if you were sent to boot camp?
3. Where would be a suitable location for a boot camp in Hong Kong?
4. Are there some children who should not be sent to boot camp?
5. What would be the best age to send children to a boot camp?
6. Why do you think parents spoil children?
7. What problems do spoilt children face when they become adults?
8. Why is the number of over-protected children on the increase?